

The portable hard drives are an extension of USB sticks and are light-weight. They have a much larger data storage capacity compared to a USB stick and can store anywhere between 250 GB to 1.5 TB of data.

On the other hand, the desktop external hard drives are comparatively bigger and are best used as a back-up device sitting next to your computer, or as an additional hard drive. Both these storage devices can be connected to the computers via a USB cable. These drives are good to store 500GB to 4TB data, which means you can store practically everything on them.

They are apt and pocket-friendly options for local storage of large volumes of data. The only catch is that they have to be handled with a lot of care, and they can be damaged if dropped or during electrical surges.

3. Solid state drives (SSDs). Although they function almost the same way as the traditional magnetic drives, these drives do not have rotatory platters or moving parts, hence are more robust and consume less power. The makers of SSDs are working to bring down the price and power consumption of these devices. They are most suitable for mobile devices and laptops. For those who want faster performance (both in the reading and writing of data), robust and reliable quality and portable storage devices, SSDs are a perfect choice. They typically offer 64 to 256 GB of storage capacity and are expensive compared to the traditional drives.

4. Multimedia hard drives. For all those who love to carry their multimedia content with them, multimedia hard drives are the right choice. They allow you to view pictures or watch movies via your television in high-definition format. Most of the currently available multimedia hard drives store one to two TB of data. There are some cheaper options available that do not have built-in storage but can be connected to your hard drive to send content to the TV.

5. Network attached storage (NAS). These networking hard drives work through Wi-Fi or routers and allow access to multiple users at the same time. So they are perfect for small

businesses or families as they facilitate wireless sharing. If connected right, NAS also allows users to connect to them via the Internet. Of course, the storage device has to be switched on at that time. Network attached storage also allows you to save content wirelessly, even if you forget about it. This is possible by implementing automated scheduled backups. Also, users can stream content on their TVs, different computers or mobile devices through NAS. These drives can store a large volume of data as several hard drives can be connected to them. They are comparatively much more expensive.

6. Digital versatile discs (DVD). DVDs are good for storing songs, movies and software for distribution purposes. They are inexpensive and are capable of storing data anywhere between 4.7 GB and 17.08 GB. Since they have a shorter life span, they do not make for a very good long-term storage option. They are not as reliable as external hard drives.

Some features you must look for

1. Do check out the 'shock protection' feature if you are buying a portable hard drive to carry around with you.
2. The password protection feature is important for people looking to store sensitive data in their storage devices.
3. Automatic backup is also a useful feature that comes with a lot of reliability. This feature allows users to keep copies of their work in case they change or delete anything.
4. Although a lot of devices that require to be connected to the computer use USB 2.0, USB 3.0 is the latest standard. It is three times as fast and allows quicker copying of data. Do keep in mind that both your computer and the drive should support this new standard.
5. Don't forget to check the compatibility of the storage device with your computer. If you are a Mac or Linux user, this is a must for you.
6. Do check out the online stores to get some of the best deals on storage devices.

HERE'S A GLIMPSE OF SOME PRODUCTS AVAILABLE IN THE MARKET:

Kingston 4GB G3 Pen Drive

Hi-Speed USB, Read: 10MBps, Write: 5MBps, USB 2.0, Weight: 11.3 gm, Dimensions: 66.9 x 20.4 x 9.0 mm, Works with virtually any device that has a USB port, PC and MAC compatibility, 4GB storage.



Price: ₹ 699

HP v250W 16GB USB Flash Drive

Hi-Speed USB, Read: 15MBps, Write: 4MBps, USB 2.0, OS required: Windows Me/2000/XP/Vista or above and Mac, Dimensions: 46.6 x 15.8 x 5.0 mm, PC and MAC compatibility, 16GB storage, Compatible ports: USB 3.0/2.0/1.1



Price: ₹ 999

Sandisk CZ50 Cruiser Blade 32GB USB Drive

Hi-Speed USB, USB 2.0, OS required: Windows 2000, Windows XP or Windows Vista, Mac OS X v10.3.5; includes UFD technology and U3 Smart capable Flash drive, PC and MAC compatibility, 32 GB



Price: ₹ 1862